▼ GLASSHOUSE



DEFENDERS FROM THE EAST

Assam CM **Himanta Biswa Sarma** has really taken to his role as the BJP's rhetorical assault weapon, firing verbal salvos at will across borders. After 'Operation Sindoor', Sarma gleefully reminded anyone in range of India's might, even endorsing the Balochistan freedom struggle to needle Islamabad. And when Bangladesh interim chief Muhammad Yunus crossed the line over the "chicken's neck" linking the Northeast to the rest of India, Sarma sent a shrill reminder that they, too, have two vulnerable corridors. But now the Assam CM has competition near home—Tripura's titular king and Tipra Motha chief **Pradyot Debbarma** has taken the tit-for-tat with Dhaka a step further, saying India could carve out a new nation if push comes to shove. Looks like the Northeast netas are walking around strapped, ever ready to rain hellfire with just enough plausible deniability.

Illustrations by **SIDDHANT JUMDE**

▼ FAMILY TIME

DYNASTY RELOADED



Guess blood is thicker than water. The return of **Akash Anand,** the nephew of BSP chief Mayawati, and his appointment as the party's Chief National Coordinator, a new post that makes him the "second most powerful leader in the party", is giving a few of the old guard sleepless nights. Sources say Akash has been tasked with leading the BSP programmes and yatras across states and, pertinently, overseeing all national coordinators and state unit presidents. This time around, Behenji may have stopped short of calling him her political successor, but there is little doubt the young 'un has his hands on the party reins. Already there's a diktat that 'non-performing' mandal in-charges will be axed, and sources say the purge may include those responsible for Anand's earlier ouster.